

**SWING-CLIPPER
CHRONICLES**
A SKYBOUND SAGA

ISSUE # **27**

GRAVITY BREAK STORM

THE SHIP TURNS.
THE CREW HOLDS.
TRUST BREAKS.

PULSE OF
THE STORM
PART 3 OF 4

TETHER OF BETRAYAL

- A SWING-CLIPPER CHRONICLES EPISODE

Renn. Sloane. Silas The Drop.

*Three will hold.
One will fall.*

STORM LEVEL

9.8

GRAVITY SHEAR
CRITICAL

DAWN.
SOMEWHERE ABOVE
THE SPLINTER CHASM.

SPIRAL TETHER--
AWAY!

THWIP!

WINCH
TAUT.
KEEP HER
LINES TRUE.

GROONK!

KREEEEE!

WHOOOSH!

ANOTHER
SPIRE!
ON IT!

PORT BY
TWELVE!
NOW!

TICK!
TICK!
TICK!

RENN
SLOANE
& BIX

SWING-CLIPPER INTERIOR. THIRD WATCH.

WE CUT
ACROSS THE RIDGE.
FASTEST LINE.

FASTEST
IS NOT SAFEST,
RENN.

THE OLD
SUBSIDENCE PATH
IS STABLE. AND
PREDICTABLE.

B-BUT THE
SEISMIC VARIANCE
SUGGESTS MICRO-
FRACTURES ALONG
THAT CORRIDOR
AND IF—

THREE PATHS.
THREE INSTINCTS.
ONE RUIN THAT
DOESN'T CARE.

SIDEWAYS RUIN

SEISMOGRAPH

RISK IS
THE ONLY WAY
WE GET AHEAD
OF THE STORM.

DISCIPLINE
KEEPS US
ALIVE LONG
ENOUGH TO
REACH IT.

DATA KEEPS
US FROM
DYING
STUPID.

CODA WANTS
ATTENTION.

CODA THINKS
YOU'RE ALL
LOUD.

MM?

SHE'S RIGHT
THOUGH.

WE MOVE
LIKE WE
MEAN IT.

WE MOVE
LIKE WE
ENDURE.

THERE IS
A DIFFERENCE.

I-I CAN
MODEL BOTH
VARIABLES
GIVE ME—

FIFTEEN
MINUTES.

PLEASE.

THERE ARE STORMS...
AND THEN THERE ARE
IMPOSSIBILITIES.

WHAT IN
THE SEVEN
HELLS IS
THAT...?

KRAAAACK

IT DOESN'T
ROLL IN.

IT HUNTS.

SHE'S
COMING IN
SIDEWAYS...

NO... IT'S
NOT NATURAL...

HOLD FAST!
ALL HANDS
ON DECK!

B-BUT
LOOK AT
THIS!

THE NEEDLE'S
NOT JUST
SPINNING—IT'S
OSCILLATING
IN HARMONICS!

THERE'S NO
ATMOSPHERIC
MODEL THAT
PREDICTS THIS!

IT SHOULDN'T
BE POSSIBLE!

CAPTAIN! YOU
HAVE TO SEE
THIS!

IT'S READING
ENERGY... BUT
NOT LIKE WIND OR
PRESSURE—

IT'S
SOMETHING
ELSE!

I'VE
NEVER SEEN
NOTHING LIKE
THAT...

SHE'S
GAINING ON
US TOO FAST!

IT'S NOT
JUST A
STORM...

IT'S
ALIVE.

THREE HALF
HITCHES...NO,
MAKE THAT FOUR.

FACTOR WIND SHEAR AN'
DECK PITCH.... TENSION
VECTOR AT 3.7...
... HOLD, HOLD...

+ 3.7 x
= $\frac{3.7}{38}$

TIGHTEN.

CINCH.

CHK

STARBOARD
CRATE SHIFTING!
HOLD FAST!

FEED THROUGH.
LOCK AND LOAD.
WEATHER SIDE
INCREASES.
PREPARE FOR
FULL GUST FRONT.

CHK

SHE'S
COMING
IN FAST!

...IF WIND
SPEED DOUBLES
BEFORE PEAK...

LOAD LIMIT
EXCEEDED...
WE LOSE
THE PORT
STABILIZER...
...NO, WAIT—

—IF REN'S
GAUNTLET HOLDS AND
SLOANE'S
ANGLES
ARE TRUE...

...WE RIDE
THE FRONT.
BARELY.
BUT WE
RIDE.

TEN-
SION.

LOCK-
DOWN.

WE SLAMMED INTO
THE LEADING EDGE
OF THE STORM.

IN AN INSTANT...

...GRAVITY
DIDN'T JUST
SHIFT—

IT
SCREAMED.

HOLD THE
LINES!

TIE DOWN
EVERYTHING!

LOOSE OBJECTS.
WATER. PEOPLE.

ALL DRIFTING SIDeways.
UPWARDS.

NOT FALLING.

WHAT IS
THIS
PLACE?!

GRIP TIGHTER!

IF WE LET GO,
WE'LL NEVER
FIND DOWN
AGAIN!

THE STORM
DOESN'T JUST
RAGE—

IT
REWRITES
THE RULES.

CHAPTER 43:
"THE SKY
TURNED AGAINST US

WHY IS
THE RAIN
FALLING
UP...?

GRAVITY'S
INVERTED!



THE
WHOLE
WORLD...

...IS
UPSIDE
DOWN!

SECURE
LOOSE
GEAR!

TIGHTEN
YOUR
TETHERS!

WELCOME
TO THE
UPSIDE
STORM.



SNAP!

—?!

WHAT WAS
THAT...?

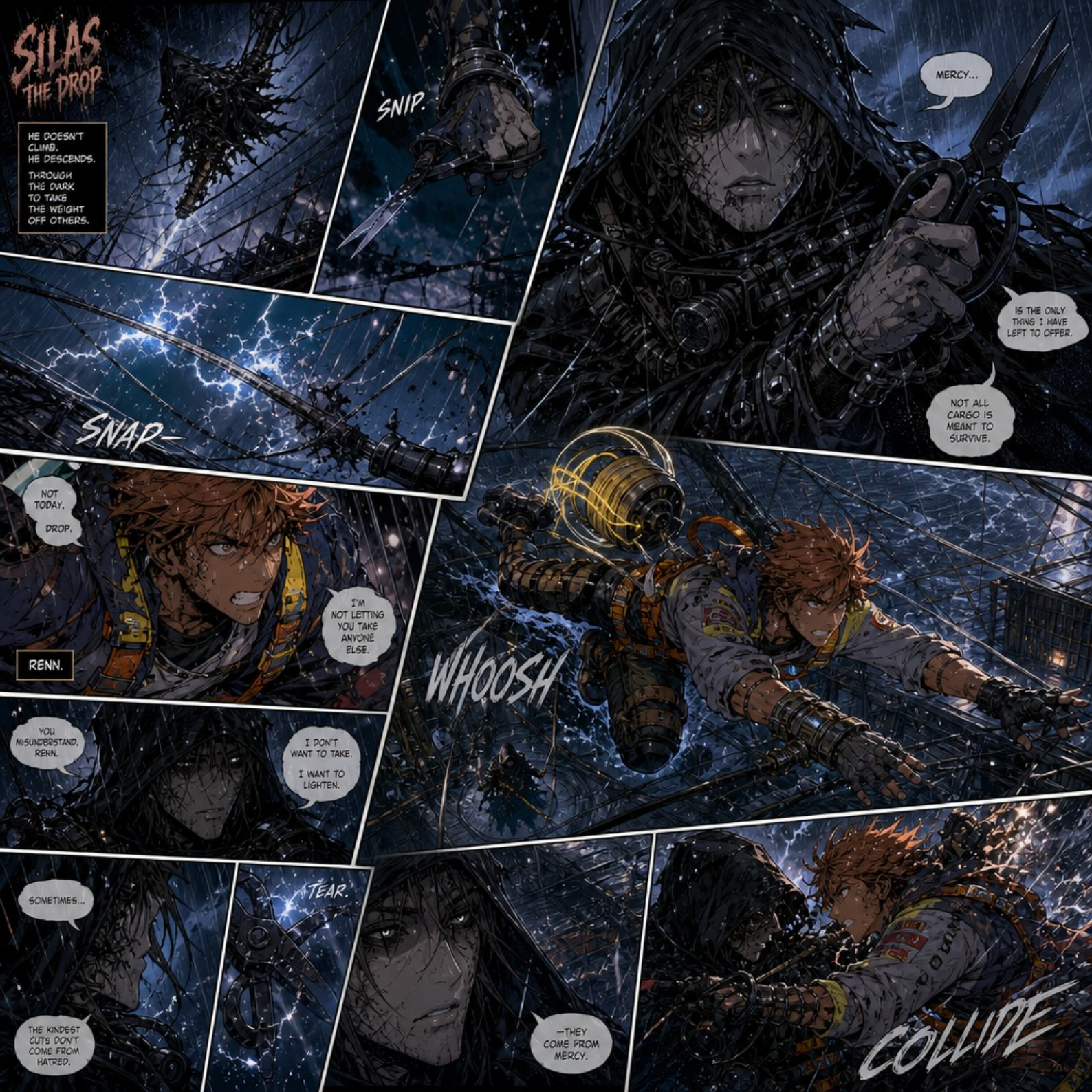
SOMETHING
MOVED UP THERE.

NOT THE WIND.

NOT THE CREW.

SOMEONE.

AND THEY'RE
GONE.



SILAS
THE DROP

HE DOESN'T
CLIMB.
HE DESCENDS.
THROUGH
THE DARK
TO TAKE
THE WEIGHT
OFF OTHERS.

SNIP.

MERCY...

IS THE ONLY
THING I HAVE
LEFT TO OFFER.

NOT ALL
CARGO IS
MEANT TO
SURVIVE.

SNAP

NOT
TODAY.
DROP.

RENN.

I'M
NOT LETTING
YOU TAKE
ANYONE
ELSE.

YOU
MISUNDERSTAND,
RENN.

I DON'T
WANT TO TAKE.
I WANT TO
LIGHTEN.

WHOOSH

SOMETIMES...

TEAR.

THE KINDEST
CUTS DON'T
COME FROM
HATRED.

—THEY
COME FROM
MERCY.

COLLIDE

DECK SEVENTEEN.
GRAVITY SHEAR
DELTA-VECTOR

3.7

TENSION
TETHER,
THREE.

FRAGILE
MAG-LOCK
COMPONENTS

MASS 84.7 KILOS,
TRAJECTORY
VECTOR 283—
IMPACT IN
T-MINUS 1.6—

ANCHOR
DRIVE.
ENGAGED.

ROTATIONAL
DRIFT $\div$ 2.3
DEGREES PER
SECOND...
CENTER OF MASS
SHIFTING...

IF RENN'S
TETHER HOLDS,
WE CAN USE THE
REBOUND TO
REALIGN BUT—

TWO
POINT
PICK!

GOT
IT!

KRNCHH

NEW
CALCULATION!
IF WE USE THE
CARGO SWING AS
A PENDULUM, WE
CAN SLINGSHOT
AROUND THE—

TARGET
ACQUIRED.
VANGUARD
CADENCE:
THIRD
FORM.

FALLEN
STAR.

KABOON



JUST ONE MORE.



?!



THE MAST!



IT'S THE LAST LINE!!
THE WHOLE MAST WILL FALL!

BIX
KEEPER OF THE SEISMOGRAPH
VOICE OF REASON. BODY OF A SCARED CHILD.



THE LAST LINE...



IT CAN'T BE...





ONE MAST.
ONE STRIKE.
ONE BREATH.

TRUST IS
THE ONLY LINE
THAT HOLDS.

RENN
TETHER
ENGAGE.

--?!

SLOANE
ANCHOR
SET.



TETHER OUT.
LINE TAKEN.



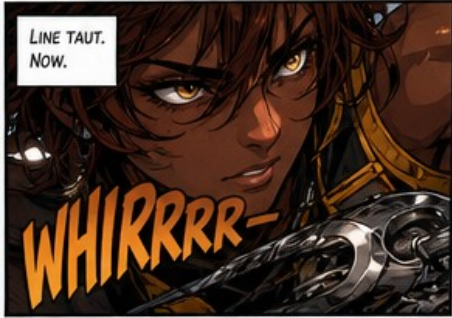
GAH--!

TARGET
ACQUIRED.



ANCHOR
DOWN.
HOLD
FAST.

KRAAANG



LINE TAUT.
NOW.

WHIRRRR--



HOLD
THE ANGLE!

GROOOOON--



INCHES.
NOT FEET.
INCHES.

THAT'S ALL
THAT STANDS
BETWEEN US
AND DISASTER.



TOGETHER.
OR NOT AT ALL.

SILAS "THE DROP".

SCAVENGER. DIVER.
ONCE HUMAN.
NOW—SOMETHING
BEYOND THAT.

HM.

STILL
BREATHING,
YOU TWO.

IMPRESSIVE.

!!

YOU CLING
SO TIGHT...

...TO A
WORLD THAT
SINKS.

WHAT'S IT
LIKE...

...TO STILL
BELIEVE IN
SOLID
GROUND?

WHSSSSHHH

I USED TO
FALL FOR
THINGS
LIKE THAT.

GRAVITY.
MERCY.

NOW?
I JUST...

...LET
GO.

KREEEK...
...TOK

...TOK

THERE'S A
KIND OF MERCY
DOWN THERE.

I THINK...
I REMEMBER
NOW.





WE BROKE
THROUGH.

THE STORM
RELEASED ITS GRIP,
AND THE WORLD
REMEMBERED
ITS LIGHT.



GRAVITY
SNAPPED LIKE
A WHIPCRACK—

AND EVERYTHING
CAME CRASHING
BACK DOWN.



UNGH...!

★
THWDD!



WE'RE...
THROUGH?



"HUFF"
I THINK SO...



C-CODA?



Y-YOU
OKAY...?

SOME THINGS
NEVER LET GO.

DUSK.
AFTER THE STORM.



SHE'LL
HOLD.

BARELY.



GOOD
ENOUGH.

THAT'S ALL
WE EVER GET.



YOU EVER
THINK ABOUT
WHAT WE'LL DO
WHEN THIS IS
ALL OVER?

I MEAN, AFTER
WE'VE SAVED THE
WORLD AND ALL
THAT.



NO.

I THINK ABOUT
WHAT WE NEED
TO DO NEXT.

THAT'S ALL.

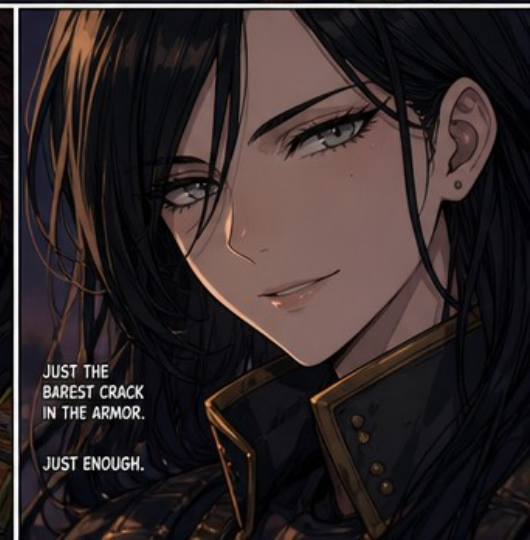


YEAH, WELL...

NEXT, WE
FIND SOMEWHERE
THAT HAS REAL
COFFEE.

AND MAYBE A
DOCK THAT DOESN'T
TRY TO KILL US.
CRAZY, I KNOW.

SLOANE ALLOWED
HERSELF A RARE
SMILE.



JUST THE
BAREST CRACK
IN THE ARMOR.

JUST ENOUGH.

THE SEISMOGRAPH
NEVER LIES...

BUT SHE
DOESN'T
SUGARCOAT
EITHER.

TICK
TICK
TICK

NEW FRACTURE
DETECTED.

MAGNITUDE
INCREASING.

VECTOR LOCKED.
CALIPER RUINS.
DISTANCE...

TICK

IT'S
MOVING.

TOWARD
THE RUINS.

AND IT'S
NOT SLOWING
DOWN.

THERE'S
NOTHING
BETWEEN
IT AND THE
CALIPER
EXCEPT US.

SOME LINES
ON A MAP
AREN'T JUST
DATA.

TICK
TICK

TICK
TICK

SOME LINES
ARE
SENTENCES.

TO BE CONTINUED...